No Easy Start

Gone are the glory days when newcomers were launched with fanfare. Think Hrithik Roshan in *Kaho Naa... Pyaar Hai* (2000) or Deepika Padukone in *Om Shanti Om* (2007). It's hard to see actors make a good first impression as Ranveer Singh did fabulously in *Band Baaja Baaraat* (2010) or Anushka Sharma in *Rab Ne Bana Di Jodi* (2008). The young brigade is having to fight harder to win audience's hearts. In fact, the last feature with a debutant to make a decent dent at the box office was Tiger Shroff in *Heropanti* (2014) and *Kedarnath* (2018) featuring Sara Ali Khan.

Bhavana Somaya, author, critic and former editor of *Screen* magazine, has seen the change from the time of grand launches when the industry would come together to rally behind a star kid to the dull affairs that debuts have now become. "Raj Kapoor, Sunil Dutt, Dharmendra and Rajendra Kumar would launch their kids with much *shaan*. They put their own money and ensured their son looked like a star in the first film itself," she recalls, citing films like *Bobby* (1973), *Rocky* (1981), *Love Story* (1981) and *Betaab* (1983), which introduced Hindi cinema to Rishi Kapoor, Sanjay Dutt, Kumar Gaurav and Sunny Deol. "Now, people's attitude is, let us be as low-profile as possible so that there are no expectations. Nobody wants to carry the blame and baggage if a launch doesn't work. The showmanship and self-confidence are gone." Instead of family-run banners, new talent is now being entrusted to noteworthy directors for mentorship and presenting them on a platform that best showcases their attributes.

Trust SRK to buck the trend then. At a recent Netflix event in Mumbai, the Badshah went all-out to announce the web series *The Ba***ds of Bollywood*, the directorial debut of his eldest, Aryan. Produced by his banner Red Chillies Entertainment, Khan featured in a special promotional video where the actor is shown growing irate as a director [read Aryan] asks him to give multiple takes, until he lambasts him, "*Tere baap ka raaj hai kya* [Is it your dad's kingdom]?" SRK said his only request to the world was that both his kids—Aryan and Suhana—be given "50 per cent of the love" he has received. The series, he added, showed that his son had inherited his humorous streak. "*Ab tu jaa aur apne baap ka naam roshan kar* [Go and do your father proud]," SRK said as he passed the baton of cracking jokes to his son.

For Junaid, the journey to acting was a tad different from other kids with cinema in their DNA. As a child, he didn't grow up on Hindi films but preferred *Lion King* (1994) and *Mary Poppins* (1964) instead. It's only in college—HR College of Commerce and Economics—that films became a part of his life. "Nobody wanted to go to



Aaman Devgan
He didn't have a smashing big screen debut like his uncle Ajay Devgn did—remember the split on two bikes in Phool aur Kaante*—but he will hope to be second-time lucky*

Ibrahim Ali Khan
Much like Varun Dhawan and Sidharth Malhotra before him, Saif Ali Khan and Amrita Singh's son Ibrahim assisted director Karan Johar and went on to earn his big Bollywood break. In his OTT debut Nadaaniyan*, he plays a pretend boyfriend to a rich girl (Khushi Kapoor)*



"FILMS ARE IN THEIR BLOOD, THEIR GENES, AND THEIR PASSION. WE MAKE WAY FOR A NEW WAVE OF TALENT, ONE I CANNOT WAIT FOR THE WORLD TO SEE"

KARAN JOHAR, *Director*